What is a behavioral interview?

Design Gurus

Here are a few behavioral questions related to communication skills:

Question 1: How do you handle receiving constructive criticism from your peers or supervisors? Can you provide an example?

Intention of the question: The interviewer wants to know whether feedback changes your behavior or only your mood. They are listening for a specific piece of feedback you can still repeat, which is the sign that it landed.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid saying you welcome all feedback and stopping there. Do not choose feedback that flatters you, such as caring too much or working too hard. Do not describe how it felt without the change that followed.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "In my second year, my tech lead told me in a review that my pull requests were hard to review. I had been treating the size of my changes as evidence of how much I shipped. He showed me the number. My average pull request was about 900 lines and the team median was 150."

Task: "I did not agree at first. My changes were large because the features were large. But the review data was hard to argue with. My changes sat in review for about four days and everyone else's went through in one."

Action: "I asked him to review one of my recent pull requests out loud with me, so I could see where he lost track. He got about 200 lines in before he stopped being able to hold the whole change in his head. That was the part I had misunderstood. The cost was not his time, it was his confidence in approving it. So I changed how I planned work rather than how I wrote it. I began splitting a feature into four or five changes before writing any code. Each one was safe to ship on its own behind a flag."

Result: "My average pull request went from about 900 lines to about 180 over the next quarter. Review time dropped from four days to one. Two reviewers told me they read my changes first because they were quick. The feedback I received was about pull requests, but the thing I had to change was how I planned. I would have missed that if I had not asked him to walk through one with me."

Sample Answer 2: "Later a designer told me I interrupted her in meetings. My first reaction was that I was building on her point rather than interrupting. I asked a colleague to count it in our next two meetings. It was eleven times in ninety minutes, nine of them to her. I could not argue with a count. I started writing my thought down instead of saying it, and only raising it if it still mattered when she finished. About half of them did not. She told me two months later that our meetings had changed. Asking for a number turned a disagreement about my intent into a fact about my behavior."

Follow-up you should expect: "Tell me about feedback you received and decided not to act on."

Why they ask: A candidate who acted on every piece of feedback has either never received difficult feedback or is not telling the truth. They want to see judgment, not obedience.

How to answer it: "A manager once told me to stop writing design documents for small changes, because they slowed me down. I tried it for a month and my rework went up. So I kept the documents and cut them to one page instead of four. I told him what I had tried and what the result was. He was right that they were too long and wrong that they should go. Feedback is usually accurate about the problem and only a guess at the fix."

Intention of the question: The interviewer wants to see whether the people who fund and use your work can understand you. They are also checking whether you know what the other person actually had to decide.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid saying you avoided jargon and used an analogy, then stopping. Every candidate says that. Do not describe the audience as slow. Say what decision they had to make and what they did with your explanation.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "Our checkout was failing for about 2 percent of customers during peak hours. The fix needed a four-hour maintenance window on a Saturday. I had to get agreement from our head of sales, because he would have to tell customers."

Task: "He did not need to understand connection pooling. He needed to decide whether four hours of planned downtime was better than 2 percent of checkouts continuing to fail. My job was to give him the comparison, not the diagnosis."

Action: "I stopped explaining the cause. Instead I wrote both options as things his customers would experience. Option one: about 340 customers hit a failed checkout every week, at unpredictable times, with no warning we could give them. Option two: nobody can check out for four hours on a Saturday morning, announced ten days ahead. I put those two lines in an email with nothing else in it. He asked one question, which was whether the 340 were the same customers each week. I did not know, so I checked. They were not, which made it worse, because the problem was spreading across the customer base."

Result: "He approved the window that same day and chose the Saturday himself, because he knew our order pattern better than I did. Checkout failures dropped from 2 percent to under 0.1 percent. What I kept from this is that explaining to a non-technical audience is not mainly about simpler words. It is about restating the choice in the units that person is responsible for."

Sample Answer 2: "In another role I had to explain to our support team why a bug they reported was taking three weeks to fix. Calling it a race condition meant nothing to them. So I showed them instead. I ran the failing case twice on a screen share, and it passed once and failed once with nothing changed in between. That took four minutes. They stopped asking why the fix was slow and started recording the exact timestamp of every report, which is what finally let me reproduce it. Showing a behavior is usually faster than describing a cause."

Follow-up you should expect: "Has an explanation of yours ever failed? What happened?"

Why they ask: They want to know whether you notice when you have not been understood, or only when somebody complains.

How to answer it: "Yes. I told a product manager that a migration was low risk, and he heard no risk. He committed to a launch date in the same week. What I meant was that failure was unlikely but would take a day to recover from. Since then I give risk as two numbers: how likely, and how long to recover. Low risk means whatever the listener wants it to mean. He and I now write the recovery time into the launch plan itself."

Question 3: What is the most critical feedback you've received from your boss in your entire career?

Intention of the question: The interviewer wants the hardest thing you have been told, and wants to see whether you can say it plainly. Which piece of feedback you choose tells them more than your answer does.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid choosing something harmless. Do not argue that it was unfair. Do not choose something you fixed within a week, because that says the feedback was easy.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "Three years in, my manager told me in a review that two people on the team had stopped raising problems, and that I was the reason. I had been the most experienced engineer on a team of five for about a year."

Task: "My first reaction was that I was being blamed for being right. Then he gave me an example I could not explain away. In a design discussion the previous month, a junior engineer asked a question. I answered with a reason we had rejected her idea two years earlier. She did not speak again in that meeting, or in the next four."

Action: "I asked him for a second example, and then a third, because one could be an accident. All three had the same shape. I answered a question using history the other person did not have, and the history ended the conversation. So I changed one thing. I stopped answering design questions first. In every design discussion after that, I asked the least senior person in the room for their view before I gave mine. I wrote my own opinion down beforehand, so I was not tempted to adjust it afterwards."

Result: "It took about six months before that engineer proposed something in a meeting again. She is a senior engineer on that team now. Two years later I still do not speak first in a design review. The feedback was that I was shutting people down. What I actually had to change was the order I spoke in, which is much smaller than it sounded and much harder to keep doing."

Sample Answer 2: "Earlier in my career a manager told me my estimates were not wrong, they were useless, because I only ever gave one number. He asked how confident I was in a two-week estimate and I said fairly. He asked what fairly meant and I could not answer him. I started giving a range with the assumption that would break it. Two to four weeks, and four if the vendor API turns out to be undocumented. My estimates did not become more accurate. But my manager stopped padding them privately, which he told me he had been doing by about 50 percent."

Follow-up you should expect: "What feedback do you think your current team would give you that you have not heard yet?"

Why they ask: This is the harder version of the same question. They want to know whether you hold a view of your own weaknesses that does not depend on somebody telling you.

How to answer it: "I think two of them would say I reach a decision too early in a discussion. I notice it when a meeting ends and somebody messages me afterwards with the point they did not get to make. That is my own signal rather than something I have been told. I have started ending design reviews by asking what we did not discuss. About a third of the time somebody has something. I do not have a number that says it is fixed."